Katarzyna Andrzejewska

CONTENTS

Introduction 1
“Il dolce suono mi colpí di sua voce”/”The Sweet sound hits me, his voice” 2
“Never Let Me Go” 4
„Die Wahrheit, die Wahrheit sei sie auch Verbrechen.“ /“The truth. That’s what we will say‘ 5
Conclusion 7
Bibliography 7

How (not) to be an android

INTRODUCTION

Rick Deckard is a bounty hunter in Philip K. Dick’s novel *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* whose job consists in killing androids which have fled their fate of being human servants in the colonies and escaped to Earth to lead their lives independently from their creators. The androids of the Nexus-6 generation resemble humans to such a degree that they are undistinguishable from them except for their lack of ability to feel empathy towards humans and animals. As a result, specially designed psychological Voigt-Kampff tests need to be conducted in order to confirm that a target is indeed an android. While pondering about the nature of androids Rick Deckard reflects on the nature of being human and on mortality by referencing the composer Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart and his work:

> *„And Mozart, not long after writing The Magic Flute, had died--in his thirties--of kidney disease. And had been buried in an unmarked pauper's grave.*
>
> *Thinking this, he wondered if Mozart had any intuition that the future did not exist, that he had already used up his little time. Maybe I have too, Rick thought as he watched the rehearsal move along. This rehearsal will end, the performance will end, the singers will die, eventually the last score of the music will be destroyed in one way or another; finally the name "Mozart" will vanish, the dust will have won. If not on this planet then another. We can evade it awhile. As the andys can evade me and exist a finite stretch longer. But I will get them or some other bounty hunter gets them. In a way, he realized, I'm part of the form-destroying process of entropy.”*

A few of Mozart’s operas are mentioned throughout the novel. The reader’s attention, however, is directed principally towards *The Magic Flute* which Rick Deckard watches in the opera house where he spots an android within the cast. One of the major threads in *The Magic Flute* is prince Tamino’s quest to find Pamina on which he embarks after being handed her picture by the three ladies on the Queens of the Night’s request. He even ponders on the picture of the girl which

he has to find in the aria *Dies Bildnis ist bezaubernd schön./Oh imagine angel-like and fair*[1]. The quest of the bounty hunter Rick and Tamino's search for Pamina is only one of the few analogies I could draw between the opera and Philip K. Dick's novel. The trials which Pamino and Tamina have to undergo could be compared to the tests that the androids have to pass. Also, the unintelligent and naive but having his heart in the right place bird catcher Papageno reminds me of John Isidore who is living on Earth as he his genes have been damaged resulting in a low IQ. However, their empathy and longing for a reciprocation and acknowledgement of their feelings lead to actions which endanger their lives, in case of John Isidore it is inviting androids home and protecting them and in Papageno's case a suicide attempt.

Because of the many references to Mozart's work, which is one of my favourite operas, I intend to analyse in this essay how Philip K. Dick but as well other authors of science fiction have chosen musical references in order to support the question of being human or not human.

"IL DOLCE SUONO MI COLPÍ DI SUA VOCE"/"THE SWEET SOUND HITS ME, HIS VOICE"[2]

Rick Deckard is faced in his day-to-day job with the challenge of distinguishing between humans and androids. While on mission to retire androids of the most recent generation, Rick discovers that his feelings go beyond considering androids mere technological constructs and he is experiencing attraction and empathy towards some of their representants. One of them is the opera singer Luba Luft whom he watches perform Pamina's part in Mozart's opera *The Magic Flute*:

> *"Rick said, 'I'm capable of feeling empathy for at least specific, certain androids. Not for all of them but - one or two.' For Luba Luft, as an example, he said to himself. So I was wrong. There's nothing unnatural or inhuman about Phil Resch's reactions; it's me.*
>
> *I wonder, he wondered, if any human has ever felt this way before about an android.*
>
> *Of course, he reflected, this may never come up in my work; it could be an anomaly, something for instance to do with my feelings for The Magic Flute. And for Luba's voice, in fact her career as a whole. Certainly this had never come up before; or at least not that he had been aware of."3*

Luba Luft is not the first non-human singer who makes a protagonist face such a dilemma. Another artificial human with musical skills so superb that a protagonist develops feelings for her is the mechanical doll Olimpia from the German writer's E.T.A. Hoffman short story

---

[1] *Jonas Kaufmann: Mozart - Die Zauberflöte, 'Dies Bildnis Ist bezaubernd schön'.*
[2] Donizetti, *Lucia Di Lammermoor*.
[3] Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, 113.

Sandman[4]. Olimpia sings, dances and plays the harpsichord and is even granted her own aria in Jacque Offenbach's opera *The Tales of Hoffmann* called *Les oiseaux dans la charmille*, commonly known as *Doll's song*. Jacques Offenbach reflects Olimpia's robotic qualities not only in the story based on E.T.A. Hoffman's tales but also in his music. One example is when the automaton needs winding up after she gets stuck during her aria on the top b flat[5]. Even so, Hoffmann does not believe that Olimpia could be a robot and falls in love with her.

The not common range and extreme precision of the coloratura sopranos is certainly not a characteristic of every human and is an object of fascination. In Luc Besson's movie *The Fifth Element* the aria from the *Mad Scene* from Gaetano Donizetti's *Lucia di Lammermoor* is performed in front of a full opera house by Diva Plavalaguna[6]. The performance bridges the gap not being human but simultaneously evoking emotions in humans through singing another coloratura soprano aria. The aria from Gaetano Donizetti's opera *Lucia di Lammermoor* is sung by Lucia sings when she goes mad after killing her husband Arturo and in case of Diva Plavalaguna is prescient of her getting killed.

Though the music in all the above cases is not performed by humans, it appeals strongly to their listeners and evokes human emotions. Even more, it creates the illusion that the music must be performed by a human being as it makes us feel very human ourselves - we can read on the audience's faces how Diva Plavalaguna's performance enchants them, Hoffmann falls in love with Olimpia and doesn't believe that she is a robot. Luba Luft evokes emotions in humans while playing the role of Pamina but, as it turns out during Rick's backstage meeting with Luba, she remains unmoved herself by the music and the character she portrays, ironic for a character whose main aria starts with the words *Ach ich fühl's/Ah, I feel*[7]. Rick Deckard realises the danger which Luba Luft brings with her and proceed to carrying out the order of killing her:

> *"On the stage Luba Luft sang, and he found himself surprised at the quality of her voice; it rated with hat of the best, even that of notables in his collection of historic tapes. The Rosen Association built her well, he had to admit. And again he perceived himself sub specie aeternitatis, the form destroyer called forth by what he heard and saw here. Perhaps the better she functions, the better a singer she is, the more I am needed."*[8]

---

[4] Offenbach, *Tales of Hoffman. English Version by Edward Agate*.

[5] *Patricia JANEČKOVÁ: 'Les Oiseaux Dans La Charmille', Jacques Offenbach - Les Contes d' Hoffmann. 00:03:01.*

[6] *Diva Plavalaguna Song (The Fifth Element)*.

[7]

[8] Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, 78.

"NEVER LET ME GO"

Both Luba Luft and Olimpia wake in us feelings of fear as we get the impression that they deceive us through evoking emotions which they don't have themselves. However, to consider their behaviour deceptive we must understand that they were created with another goal in mind than making us feel emotional. What did the creators have in mind when creating robots or androids and have their creations gone beyond fulfilling the function that they were designed for?

In Mary Shelley's gothic novel "Frankenstein" the goal of the creator was to attain new levels of science:

> *"It was the secrets of heaven and earth that I desired to learn; and whether it was the outward substance of things or the inner spirit of nature and the mysterious soul of man that occupied me, still my inquiries were directed to the metaphysical, or in the highest sense, the physical secrets of the world."*[9]

However, little did he ponder about the possible repercussions of setting an artificial human alive. The consequences of the creation of the monster turn out to be disastrous not only for Victor Frankenstein but also for anyone connected to him. The novel has had such an influence on the imagining of artificial humans and dangers connected with them that the term Frankenstein is associated with monster in many cultures.

Since then, she is referred as the creator and her work improved upon in to make the creatures visually pleasing as in Ian McEwan's novel *Machines Like Me* in the counterfactual Britain of 1982:

> *"Miranda, a doctoral scholar of social history, said she wished the teenage Mary Shelley as here beside us, observing closely, not a monster like Frankenstein's, but this handsome young man coming to life."*[10]

As well, there is a lot of effort employed into being able to exert control over their character and personality traits, even on an individual robot item:

> *"But the manual in my hands had fallen open at Chapter Fourteen. Here, the English was plain: preferences; personality parameters. The a set of headings – Agreeableness. Extraversion. Openness to experience. Conscientiousness. Emotional stability. The list was familiar to me. The Five Factor model. Educated as I was in the humanities, I was suspicious of such reductive categories, though I knew from a friend in psychology that each item had many subgroups. Glancing at the next page I saw that I was supposed to select various settings on a scale of one to ten."*[11]

---

[9] Shelley, *Frankenstein*, n. 378.
[10] McEwan, *Machines Like Me and People Like You*, 4.
[11] McEwan, 6.

Do these efforts really pay off and the artificial humans are managed to be kept within bounds of what humans designed for? Not according to the ending of the novel as the main protagonist Charlie Friend kills his robot Adam after troubles he caused with the robot's inflexible sense of morality for Charlie.

Another example of artificial human to consider is Kathy H. in Kazuo Ishiguro's novel *Never Let Me Go*. She is a clone who has been created with the sole purpose of donating organs. We observe how she and her alikes are raised separated from the rest of the society and how they discover the truth about themselves. However, it proves the non-humans do not want to limit themselves to the functions with which in mind they were designed. There is more, as in Never Let Me Go but as well in the Dennis Villeneuve's movie sequel *Blade Runner 2049* go well beyond their original design by wanting to procreate or procreating.

> *Anyway, what I was doing was swaying about slowly in time to the song, holding an imaginary baby to my breast. In fact, to make it all more embarrassing, it was one of those times I'd grabbed a pillow to stand in for the baby, and I was doing this slow dance, my eyes closed, singing along softly each time those lines came around again:*
>
> *'Oh, baby, baby, never let me go…'*[12]

„DIE WAHRHEIT, DIE WAHRHEIT SEI SIE AUCH VERBRECHEN." /"THE TRUTH. THAT'S WHAT WE WILL SAY"[13]

While at the opera house, Rick Deckard watches the finale of act I of Mozart's *The Magic Flute* where Pamina and Papageno ponder whether to tell the truth (about what and to whom):

> *"Papageno: 'My child, what should we now say?'*
>
> *Pamina: 'The truth. That's what we will say'*
>
> *(…) This is Luba Luft. A little ironic, the sentiment her role calls for. However vital, active, and nice-looking, and escaped android could hardly tell the truth; about itself, anyhow".*[14]

In Philip K. Dick's novel and the movie sequel *Blade Runner 2049* androids are designed to tell the truth. However, in *Blade Runner 2049* the Nexus-8 android K., whose task is to kill less obedient androids from the Nexus-6 generation, lies to his superior and does not reveal that he has not killed a target assigned to him. The reason for it is that as he believes to have found out that he is the target themselves and killing himself would go against robotic laws established in Isaac Asimov's *I, Robot*, the groundwork for the rules for robots:

---

[12] Ishiguro, *Never Let Me Go*, 71.
[13] *The Magic Flute (Paris Opera, 2001). 01:02:20.*
[14] Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, 78.

> *"The Three Laws if Robotics*
>
> *1 – A robot may not injure a human being, or, though inaction, allow a human being to come to harm*
>
> *2 – A robot must obey the orders given it by human beings except where such orders would conflict with the First Law.*
>
> *3 – A robot must protect its own existence as long as such protection does not conflict with the First or Second Law.*
>
> *Handbook of Robotics, 56th Edition, 2058 A.D."*[15]

Asimov's rules have been explored in different contexts including one of truth telling as in the story *Liar!*, where hurting humans is extended to the emotional dimension/level and we see/observe the robot Herbie as we observe the robot to create a soap opera of a kind by telling Dr. Calvin that her feelings for Milton Ashe are reciprocated, among other lies created with the thought of making people happy and not hurting their feelings.

When it comes to telling the truth in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* there is one more important factor to consider. It is that the androids are referring to when establishing the truth is often their implanted memories which they are not able to recognise as being false. For this reason, a psychological Voigt-Kampff test needs to be conducted in order to determine whether the empathy level is correspondent with that of a human being. In The Magical Flute Pamina saves herself/can save herself by confessing the truth to Sarastro and saves herself from further trouble by doing so and the high priest Sarastro forgives her:

> *"Pamina:*
>
> *Sire! My offense is all too plain! I tried escape from your domain. Alas! the guilt falls not on me. The cruel Moor wants me to love him; Therefore, my lord, I tried to flee.*
>
> *Sarastro:*
>
> *Arise, console yourself, Pamina! The name of your devoted lover I need not ask you to impart, I read the secrets of your heart, all your secret heart. Through me you will not have to suffer, But yet I will not set you free. "*[16]

Unlike in *The Magic Flute* the androids don't demonstrate the skill the skill of empathy like the officer of the San Francisco Police department, who is also and android, admits:

> *"'You androids', Rick said, 'don't exactly cover for each other in times of stress.'*
>
> *Garland snapped, 'I think you're right; it would seem we lack a specific talent you humans possess. I believe it's called empathy.'"*[17]

---

[15] Asimov, *I, Robot*, loc. 30.
[16] Mozart, *The Magic Flute with an English Version by Ruth and Thomas Martin*, 73.
[17] Dick, *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*, 145.

CONCLUSION

The title of Philip K. Dick's novel *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* refers to Rick Deckard's question about what is means to be human or non-human:

> *"Do androids dream? Rick asked himself. Evidently; that's why they occasionally kill their employees and flee here. A better life, without servitude. Like Luba Luft; singing 'Don Giovanni' and 'Le Nozze' instead of toiling across the face of a barren rock-strewn field. On a fundamentally uninhabitable colony world."*[18]

Mozart's opera *The Marriage of Figaro* represents including the trouser role Cherubino disguising as a woman, characters hiding in wardrobes and jumping out of windows, finishes After a four acts and three hours it finishes with a happy ending which includes the marriage of the servants Susanna and Figaro[19]. *Don Giovanni*, on the other hand, ends badly for the title protagonist.

And while so much has changed, in the 29th century there are still Steinways and one of the major series of science fiction starts with the Hegomony Consul playing Rachmaninov's Prelude in C-sharp Minor:

> *"The Hegemony Consul sat on the balcony of his ebony spaceship and played Rachmaninov's Prelude in C-sharp Minor on an ancient while great, green saurian things surged and bellowed in the swamps below. A thunderstorm was brewing to the north. Bruise-black clouds silhouetted a forest of giant gymnosperms while stratocumulus towered nine kilometres high in a violent sky. Lightning rippled across the horizon. Closer to the ship, occasional vague, reptilian shapes would blunder into the interdiction field, cry out and then crash away through indigo mists. The consul concentrated on a difficult section of the Prelude and ignored the approach of storm and nightfall."*[20]

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Asimov, Isaac. *I, Robot*. Digital. London: Harper Voyager, 2018.

Dick, Philip K. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* London: Orion Publishing Group, 2010.

Diva Plavalaguna Song (The Fifth Element). YouTube video, 2013. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2246g7AzbMc.

Donizetti, Gaetano. *Lucia Di Lammermoor*. Milano: Casa Ricordi, 2006.

Hoffmann, Ernst Theodor Amadeus. *The Tales of Hoffmann*. Digital. London: Penguin Books Ltd., 2010.

Ishiguro, Kazuo. *Never Let Me Go*. London: Faber and Faber, 2005.

Jonas Kaufmann: Mozart - Die Zauberflöte, 'Dies Bildnis Ist Bezaubernd Schön'. YouTube video. Die Zauberflöte, 2014. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I8_IyKKj4nw.

McEwan, Ian. *Machines Like Me and People Like You*. London: Jonathan Cape, 2019.

Mitchell, David. *Cloud Atlas*. London: Hodder & Stoughton, 2004.

Mozart - Le Nozze Di Figaro Act IV. Finale - Harnoncourt (English Subtitle). YouTube video. Le Nozze Di Figaro, 2019. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5DNvGP2U4r4.

Mozart, Wolfgang Amadeus. *Don Giovanni*. 2424th ed. Milwaukee: Schirmer, n.d.

---

[18] Dick, Philip K. 2010 *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep*. London: Orion Publishing Group. P.145

[19] *Mozart - Le Nozze Di Figaro Act IV. Finale - Harnoncourt (English Subtitle)*.

[20] Simmons, Dan 2010 Hyperion. London: Hachette Digital.

———. *The Magic Flute with an English Version by Ruth and Thomas Martin*. Milwaukee: Schirmer, 1951.

———. *The Marriage of Figaro (Le Nozze Di Figaro)*. 2021st ed. Milwaukee: Schirmer, 1951.

Offenbach, Jacques. *Tales of Hoffman. English Version by Edward Agate*. New York: E.F.Kalmus, 1957. https://ks4.imslp.net/files/imglnks/usimg/e/e2/IMSLP91329-PMLP06710-Tales_of_Hoffman_Vocal_Score.pdf.

———. *Tales of Hoffman. English Version by Edward Agate*. Digital. New York: E.F.Kalmus, 1957. https://ks4.imslp.net/files/imglnks/usimg/e/e2/IMSLP91329-PMLP06710-Tales_of_Hoffman_Vocal_Score.pdf.

Patricia JANEČKOVÁ: 'Les Oiseaux Dans La Charmille', Jacques Offenbach - Les Contes d' Hoffmann. YouTube video. Les Contes d' Hoffmann, 2016. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mVUpKIFHqZk.

Shelley, Mary. *Frankenstein*. Digital. New York: Barnes & Noble, 2003.

The Magic Flute (Paris Opera, 2001). YouTube video. Die Zauberflöte, 2018. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x9nyPrJy5ek&t=3708s.